

I'm not pessimistic. Economics is the story of cycles. Things come, things go.

The unemployment rate is now the lowest it's been in decades. Wages are now actually growing faster for low-income workers than the rich.⁷⁶ College costs by and large stopped growing once grants are factored in.⁷⁷ If everyone studied advances in health care, communication, transportation, and civil rights since the Glorious 1950s, my guess is most wouldn't want to go back.

But a central theme of this story is that expectations move slower than reality on the ground. That was true when people clung to 1950s expectations as the economy changed over the next 35 years. And even if a middle-class boom began today, expectations that the odds are stacked against everyone but those at the top may stick around.

So the era of "This isn't working" may stick around.

And the era of "We need something radically new, right now, whatever it is" may stick around.

Which, in a way, is part of what starts events that led to things like World War II, where this story began.

History is just one damned thing after another.